

Region to Grape — The Complete Cheat Sheet

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Every Old World wine label hides the grape — you're expected to know it. This cheat sheet maps every major wine region to its grape variety (or varieties) and gives you the one-line style note that tells you what to expect in the glass. Color coded by wine type.

R = Red

W = White

Ro = Rosé

Sp = Sparkling

Sw = Sweet

Fo = Fortified

FRANCE

Region / Appellation	Grape Variety / Blend	Style in the Glass	Type
Pauillac · Margaux · Saint-Julien · Saint-Estèphe	<i>Cabernet Sauvignon + Merlot + Cab Franc</i>	Structured Left Bank Bordeaux — Cab Sauv leads	R
Pomerol · Saint-Émilion	<i>Merlot + Cabernet Franc</i>	Plush Right Bank Bordeaux — Merlot leads	R
Pessac-Léognan / White Bordeaux	<i>Sauvignon Blanc + Sémillon</i>	Dry white Bordeaux — lean to rich	W
Sauternes · Barsac	<i>Sémillon + Sauvignon Blanc</i>	Sweet botrytis wine — Sémillon dominant	Sw
Chablis	<i>Chardonnay</i>	Lean, unoaked, oyster-shell mineral	W
White Burgundy (Meursault · Puligny · Chassagne)	<i>Chardonnay</i>	Rich, oaked, layered — the benchmark	W
Red Burgundy (Gevrey · Chambolle · Volnay · Pommard)	<i>Pinot Noir</i>	Silky, earthy, age-worthy — the standard	R
Beaujolais (10 Crus)	<i>Gamay</i>	Light to medium red — fresh, low tannin	R
Champagne	<i>Chardonnay + Pinot Noir + Pinot Meunier</i>	Traditional method sparkling	Sp
Alsace — Riesling	<i>Riesling</i>	Mineral, precise, dry to sweet	W
Alsace — Gewurztraminer	<i>Gewurztraminer</i>	Aromatic, exotic, lychee and rose	W
Alsace — Pinot Gris	<i>Pinot Gris</i>	Rich, smoky, full-bodied for a white	W
Sancerre · Pouilly-Fumé (white)	<i>Sauvignon Blanc</i>	Mineral, citrus, flinty Loire benchmark	W
Sancerre (red)	<i>Pinot Noir</i>	Delicate, earthy Loire red	R
Vouvray · Montlouis	<i>Chenin Blanc</i>	Dry to sweet — always check the label	W
Savennières	<i>Chenin Blanc</i>	Bone-dry, age-worthy Loire white	W
Quarts de Chaume · Coteaux du Layon	<i>Chenin Blanc</i>	Sweet to very sweet Loire white	Sw
Chinon · Bourgueil · Saint-Nicolas	<i>Cabernet Franc</i>	Herbal, silky Loire red	R
Muscadet (Sèvre et Maine)	<i>Melon de Bourgogne</i>	Lean, saline — Sur Lie = extra depth	W
Côte-Rôtie	<i>Syrah (+ up to 20% Viognier co-fermented)</i>	Perfumed, peppery, smoked meat	R
Hermitage (red)	<i>Syrah</i>	Powerful, age-worthy, iron and smoke	R
Hermitage (white)	<i>Marsanne + Roussanne</i>	Rich, waxy, extraordinary ageing	W

Crozes-Hermitage · Saint-Joseph (red)	<i>Syrah</i>	More approachable Northern Rhône	R
Cornas	<i>Syrah</i>	Firm, tannic, muscular — takes age	R
Condrieu	<i>Viognier</i>	Lush, floral, stone fruit — benchmark Viognier	W
Châteauneuf-du-Pape (red)	<i>Grenache + Syrah + Mourvèdre (up to 18 varieties)</i>	Spicy, full-bodied Southern Rhône	R
Châteauneuf-du-Pape (white)	<i>Grenache Blanc + Roussanne + Clairette</i>	Rich, complex Southern Rhône white	W
Gigondas · Vacqueyras	<i>Grenache + Syrah + Mourvèdre</i>	Southern Rhône blend — value alternatives to CdP	R
Côtes du Rhône · CDV	<i>Grenache + Syrah + Mourvèdre + Cinsault</i>	Everyday Southern Rhône red	R
Bandol (red)	<i>Mourvèdre (min 50%) + Grenache + Cinsault</i>	Wild, meaty, age-worthy Provence red	R
Côtes de Provence (rosé)	<i>Grenache + Cinsault + Mourvèdre + Syrah</i>	World's benchmark dry rosé	Ro
Muscat de Beaumes-de-Venise	<i>Muscat Blanc à Petits Grains</i>	Sweet fortified Southern Rhône	Fo
Banyuls · Maury (Roussillon)	<i>Grenache</i>	Sweet fortified red — France's Port	Fo
Languedoc AOC (Faugères · Minervois etc.)	<i>Grenache + Syrah + Mourvèdre + Carignan</i>	Southern French blends — great value	R
IGP Pays d'Oc	<i>Various — grape on label</i>	Accessible French wine — variety stated	R

ITALY

Region / Appellation	Grape Variety / Blend	Style in the Glass	Type
Barolo · Barbaresco	<i>Nebbiolo</i>	Massive tannin, tar, rose — needs age	R
Barbera d'Alba · d'Asti	<i>Barbera</i>	High acid, low tannin — everyday Piedmontese red	R
Dolcetto d'Alba	<i>Dolcetto</i>	Soft, low acid, approachable — quaff in Piedmont	R
Moscato d'Asti	<i>Muscat Blanc à Petits Grains</i>	Sweet, lightly sparkling, low alcohol	Sw
Gavi (Cortese di Gavi)	<i>Cortese</i>	Light, mineral, clean northern Italian white	W
Roero Arneis	<i>Arneis</i>	Delicate, dry, pear — Piedmont's native white	W
Chianti · Chianti Classico	<i>Sangiovese (80–100%)</i>	Tart, savory, food-friendly Tuscany	R
Brunello di Montalcino	<i>Sangiovese (Brunello clone)</i>	Powerful, complex, 20+ year age potential	R
Rosso di Montalcino	<i>Sangiovese</i>	Junior Brunello — same grape, earlier drinking	R
Vino Nobile di Montepulciano	<i>Sangiovese (Prugnolo clone)</i>	Between Chianti Classico and Brunello in style	R
Morellino di Scansano	<i>Sangiovese (Morellino clone)</i>	Coastal Tuscan — richer, approachable	R
Bolgheri Sassicaia DOC	<i>Cabernet Sauvignon + Cabernet Franc</i>	Italy's most famous Bordeaux-style wine	R
IGT Toscana (Super Tuscans)	<i>Cabernet Sauvignon + Merlot + Sangiovese blends</i>	Producer-driven — grape often stated	R

Amarone della Valpolicella	<i>Corvina + Corvinone + Rondinella (air-dried)</i>	Powerful, rich, dried grape red	R
Valpolicella Ripasso	<i>Corvina + Corvinone + Rondinella (refermented on Amarone skins)</i>	Mid-weight — between Valpolicella and Amarone	R
Valpolicella (standard)	<i>Corvina + Corvinone + Rondinella</i>	Light, fresh, easy-drinking Veneto red	R
Soave Classico	<i>Garganega (dominant) + Trebbiano di Soave</i>	Mineral, almond, lean white	W
Prosecco DOC · Valdobbiadene Superiore D.O.C.G.	<i>Glera</i>	Light sparkling — Charmat method, fresh fruit	Sp
Franciacorta D.O.C.G.	<i>Chardonnay + Pinot Nero + Pinot Bianco</i>	Traditional method Italian sparkling	Sp
Etna Rosso	<i>Nerello Mascalese</i>	Volcanic, mineral, Sicily's Pinot Noir	R
Etna Bianco	<i>Carricante</i>	Saline, mineral, volcanic white	W
Nero d'Avola (Sicily)	<i>Nero d'Avola</i>	Dark, chocolatey, Mediterranean warmth	R
Primitivo di Manduria	<i>Primitivo (= Zinfandel)</i>	Jammy, high alcohol, sun-drenched Puglia	R
Aglianico del Vulture · Taurasi	<i>Aglianico</i>	Massive, tannic — the Barolo of the South	R
Fiano di Avellino	<i>Fiano</i>	Nutty, complex, honeyed Campania white	W
Greco di Tufo	<i>Greco</i>	Mineral, textured Campania white	W
Vermentino di Sardegna	<i>Vermentino</i>	Citrus, saline, herbaceous Sardinian white	W
Cannonau di Sardegna	<i>Cannonau (= Grenache)</i>	Rich, spicy Sardinian red — old vine character	R

SPAIN

Region / Appellation	Grape Variety / Blend	Style in the Glass	Type
Rioja (red)	<i>Tempranillo (60–90%) + Garnacha + Graciano + Mazuelo</i>	Dried cherry, leather, vanilla/coconut oak	R
Rioja Blanco	<i>Viura/Macabeo + Garnacha Blanca + Malvasia</i>	Aged in oak — unique oxidative white style	W
Ribera del Duero	<i>Tinto Fino / Tempranillo (min 75%)</i>	Darker, more powerful than Rioja	R
Priorat	<i>Garnacha + Cariñena + Cab Sauvignon + Syrah</i>	Mineral slate-driven, ultra-concentrated	R
Rías Baixas	<i>Albariño</i>	Saline, citrusy, the Atlantic in a glass	W
Galicia — Godello (Valdeorras · Ribeira Sacra)	<i>Godello</i>	Rich, mineral — Spain's best white aside from Albariño	W
Ribeira Sacra · Bierzo · Valdeorras (red)	<i>Mencía</i>	Herbal, fresh, Cab Franc-like — undervalued	R
Rueda	<i>Verdejo</i>	Aromatic, herbal, bright — Spain's grassiest white	W
Toro	<i>Tinto de Toro (Tempranillo)</i>	Powerful, high altitude Tempranillo — very structured	R
Jumilla · Yecla	<i>Monastrell (= Mourvèdre)</i>	Warm, meaty, dark-fruited — Mediterranean	R

Txakoli (Txakolina — Basque Country)	<i>Hondarrabi Zuri</i>	Very dry, slightly fizzy, low alcohol, saline	W
Navarra (red)	<i>Garnacha + Tempranillo + Cabernet + Merlot</i>	Diverse blends — Garnacha is the soul	R
Cava (Penedès)	<i>Macabeo + Xarel·lo + Parellada (+ Chardonnay, Pinot Noir)</i>	Traditional method sparkling — Champagne-style	Sp
Jerez — Fino · Manzanilla	<i>Palomino</i>	Bone dry, pale, saline, flor-aged	Fo
Jerez — Amontillado	<i>Palomino</i>	Amber, nutty, dry — aged Fino	Fo
Jerez — Oloroso	<i>Palomino</i>	Dark, walnut, dry to off-dry oxidative	Fo
Jerez — Palo Cortado	<i>Palomino</i>	Between Amontillado and Oloroso — rare	Fo
Jerez — Pedro Ximénez	<i>Pedro Ximénez</i>	Very dark, very sweet, raisin and molasses	Fo
Montilla-Moriles	<i>Pedro Ximénez</i>	Like Sherry but unfortified — naturally high alcohol	W

GERMANY & AUSTRIA

Region / Appellation	Grape Variety / Blend	Style in the Glass	Type
Mosel — all styles	<i>Riesling</i>	From bone-dry Trocken to TBA — minerality is constant	W
Rheingau · Nahe · Ahr	<i>Riesling (+ Pinot Noir in Ahr)</i>	Riesling benchmark — Rheingau is fuller; Ahr = elegant Pinot Noir	W
Rheinhessen (broad)	<i>Riesling + Silvaner + Dornfelder</i>	Diverse — increasingly serious Riesling	W
Pfalz	<i>Riesling + Spätburgunder (Pinot Noir)</i>	Richer than Mosel — also fine Pinot Noir	W
Franken	<i>Silvaner + Müller-Thurgau</i>	Earthy, textured — sold in distinctive flat 'Bocksbeutel' bottle	W
Baden	<i>Spätburgunder (Pinot Noir)</i>	Germany's warmest region — best Pinot Noir	R
Wachau · Kremstal · Kamptal (Austria)	<i>Grüner Veltliner + Riesling</i>	Austria's two noble whites — peppery Grüner, mineral Riesling	W
Südsteiermark (Austria)	<i>Sauvignon Blanc + Welschriesling + Morillon</i>	Vivid, crisp — Austria's aromatic white region	W
Burgenland (Austria — sweet)	<i>Welschriesling + Chardonnay + Muskat</i>	Neusiedlersee lake fog creates botrytis — world-class Ausbruch and TBA	Sw
Burgenland (Austria — red)	<i>Blaufränkisch + Zweigelt + Saint-Laurent</i>	Distinctive Austrian reds — peppery, structured	R

PORTUGAL

Region / Appellation	Grape Variety / Blend	Style in the Glass	Type
Douro (red)	<i>Touriga Nacional + Touriga Franca + Tinta Roriz blend</i>	Dense, complex, age-worthy reds	R

Porto (Port)	<i>Touriga Nacional + Touriga Franca + Tinta Roriz + Tinta Barroca + Tinto Cão</i>	Sweet fortified — Ruby (young fruit) or Tawny (oxidative aged)	Fo
Vinho Verde	<i>Alvarinho + Loureiro + Arinto + Trajadura blend</i>	Light, slightly effervescent, low alcohol — Atlantic freshness	W
Dão (red)	<i>Touriga Nacional + Alfrocheiro</i>	Elegant, mineral, restrained — Portugal's Burgundy	R
Dão (white)	<i>Encruzado</i>	Complex, textured — Portugal's most serious white variety	W
Alentejo (red)	<i>Aragonez + Trincadeira + Touriga Nacional blend</i>	Warm, generous, sun-drenched southern reds	R
Bairrada	<i>Baga</i>	High acid, firm tannin — Portugal's most age-worthy red	R
Colares (historic)	<i>Ramisco</i>	Ungrafted sandy soil vines near Sintra — very rare, very old	R